

Friends of Penelope

Volume Two



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CONTENTS

FOREWORD	3
REUNION	4
CRUMBLING ROCKS	7
ONCE UPON A TIME	10
RENDING OF CREATION	12
SINNERS	14
Y-SHAPED CITY	16

FOREWORD

ARIADNE THOMPSON

What is it about stories? Why do we go seeking real answers in fabricated worlds? Moreover, how is it that we sometimes succeed in finding them there? I don't know what answers you are seeking, dear reader, but perhaps you will find some hint here. Just remember to read closely, for stories love to deceive.

REUNION

RUADHÁN Ó DONNAILE

The festivals were always very noisy. The regulations had made it so that they were spread out—reunion had been heavily popular ever since its invention and the government were terrified of another crowd crush. Still, even here, a mass of people were stuffed into the hall of the leisure centre. The air was thick with stink and heat, and the chattering voices rose like a dissonant chorus.

I had been coming to festivals for four years, since I was eight. We had met Mum, then. It was a bit shocking, but at that age you just think “What an innovation!” The popularity of visiting a future self had only grown since.

Despite everything, I had yet to find her. It didn’t make any sense to me. I knew how badly I wanted it. I knew it was free and easy. My eyes gazed over the sea of faces, looking for a familiar flash of red, listening for a smile or a laugh—my name. I retreated to the far wall of the room, hoping to buy some time to search while I gained a small amount of reprieve from the crowd. Truthfully, it was not just that they were there. It was that they were there with themselves. There were tears, a few angry shouts, but the mood, as it always was, was mostly one of rapturous joy.

I could stand it only a few more moments, and finally gave in, pulling myself away. A grim feeling once again made its way through my guts. There were, of course, plenty of people who could not meet themselves. I had known a few. Sam died two years ago, from some heart condition. We had an assembly. Laura, who I knew but who wasn’t a friend of mine, had her future father tell her she was locked up in some facility. No access to reunion. Her whole attitude changed, and she stopped being such a troublemaker at school, but she still hasn’t met herself. As I left, I felt a little more hope. Perhaps I was somewhere similar, perhaps I could change myself so I could become someone who could come back and say hello. A little part of me felt selfish for that. I took a quick glance over my shoulder and I passed through the big glass fire exit doors. A woman showed her babies to herself and another woman, much older, who sobbed with joy. A man sat with his young self, working together on some project in their hands. A young woman took notes from two people, both of whom were engaged in lively dispute.

As the noise began to lift itself from my mind, I looked around at the various courts and pitches, sitting unused in the autumn sun.

A small pool of water had collected in the five-a-side pitch closest to me, and I forlornly sat next to it, idly skimming the water with my left hand and tapping the ground with my right, attempting to calm myself. I let out a long, heavy sigh, feeling with my hand the pouch on my backpack.

“A week left. Fourteen cigarettes if I have two a day,” I said to myself, moving my right hand to the cardboard pack inside where I slipped out a cigarette with practised ease, slipping it into my palm while my fingers felt for a lighter. “Damn. I must have forgotten it.” I quickly lost all sense of brooding mystery, upturning my bag to look for loose matches, realising such a search would be futile about halfway in, when I remembered I had no strike paper to start it with. I groaned in frustration, squeezing my cigarette with enough force to break it.

“Fuck’s sake!”

“You okay?” A man’s voice called out, nearby and fairly loud, but not unfriendly.

“Yeah, I’m fine.”

I knew enough to know most smokers wouldn’t lend a kid a lighter. The fact of the matter was, I enjoyed smoking to relieve stress, and I was going to keep doing it. My limiting factor was availability. I felt his presence remain, so I turned to face him. “Really, I’m... fine”. With a dawning surprise, I realised he must be from the future, and a relative. His hair was short, with the dark auburn of my mother, his short cropped beard like my father’s, with my own bright red colour. He wasn’t tall at all, only a few inches bigger than me, and he wore thick framed glasses that made his eyes appear big in his head, like a nerd from an ’80s American movie. He looked just as carefully at me, with the kind of awed smile I recognised from the people in the hall. He turned his head to look at my palm and went to reach into his inside coat pocket, his well-worn trench coat moving dramatically as he motioned. He produced a clipper lighter with a grin.

“You can’t bring things with you, technically—”

I took the lighter and went to grab another cigarette as he continued. “But that’s, y’know, a regulatory matter, not a material one.” He suddenly looked away and around at the centre. “Hmm, I remember this place.” I finally lit my fag as he gazed around him, pocketing the lighter without malice. He didn’t notice, or didn’t care. “I better fuck off.” He said suddenly, with a tone in his voice I couldn’t place. He had turned to study my face now, and I took the opportunity to look him up and down. He certainly wasn’t very impressive looking. Still, my heart suddenly began to lift in a kind of pre-emotion. I tried to avoid his gaze, which seemed to bore into my very soul. He turned around and began to walk off, before

stopping to shout over his shoulder “And stop smoking!” With a kind of sincerity that sent a shiver down my spine. I finished my smoke and gazed up at the autumn sky.

CRUMBLING ROCKS

ANDREW KARLYLE

Devin passed by house after house after house on his quiet country road, homes that they had salvaged from the crumbling ruins of cottages and cattle barns. The same was true for the cemetery. They jokingly called the front gate “The Door To Death” because of the skull carved into the wood, repurposed from the chapel that had stood there for hundreds of years. That skull stared him down now, its cavernous eyes seemed to bore a hole right back into his own, reminding him powerfully of the black mirrors they sometimes gazed into while nestled amongst the flowers and the headstones. It brought him a small scrap of joy to think of the good times now that they had to face the agony, crashing like waves in a storm. Like Alice’s fall.

We watched her fall.

“Devin.” His rumination broke. “You planning on asking old Skully out to dinner, or just whisking ’em off to the bushes out back?” Devin’s eyes rolled to the overcast sky, screwing up his face as he shoved Leonor *almost* into the memorial wreath.

“Such a cunt.”

“Yes, I’ve heard that rumour before, but until you provide hard evidence I’ll consider it slander.”

“Slander my arse.”

“If you insist—I’m pretty sure your arse voted Tory.” A reluctant grin came over Devin’s face, and the day seemed slightly more bearable.

“And you say you need evidence? You need some self-awareness... *and* a sodding comb!”

“Oof, I’m wounded! I think we’re going to need a second coffin because I’m about to perish from your heartless attack on my character.”

“Do you two mind? We didn’t come here to flirt today.” They parted, making way for Elise to sweep by with her long, greying golden hair floating behind her.

“*You* didn’t come here to flirt, Elise?” A teasing smirk crept onto Leonor’s face. Devin grabbed him by the arm and they followed her up the cobbled path, between the wilded grave gardens.

“Not right off the bat at least, manners and all that.” Elise winked over her shoulder as they entered the courtyard. The tables had been set out with food and drinks, and the elaborate black

decorations they had hung the day before were swaying gently in the evening breeze. They became solemn then. Climbing the steps to the ceremony chamber, the ruins of the chapel—less a chamber than an open air room now, they saw the coffin laid out before them and ‘solemn’ descended into broken grief. The chairs filled out and the ceremony seemed to go on and on, but when it was done Devin felt the snapping jaws of finality close over the lump in his throat.

“Does this mean you’re off the hook?” Elise whispered in his ear. Devin’s breath escaped through tense lips, his cheeks puffing out in a heaving sigh.

“Who knows?” He said, stomach churning at the idea of being relieved by small mercies when the cost was so high. The bench shook slightly with force when he stood suddenly to stare over the balcony into the small crowd gathering in the courtyard, throwing him furtive and pitying looks between their grieving.

We watched her fall.

The burial was quick but loud with a cacophony of sobs and sniffs from the other attendees. Their community was small and tight knit, but Devin still couldn’t cry. He didn’t know if it would be fair.

“You’ve had a loss too.” Leonor’s voice carried over his shoulder, while he wasn’t looking at Devin the penetrating vulnerability of being *seen* was something of a speciality of his. Devin had no response to give him. Long after the earth had been re-homed and the headstone found its resting place he remained by the graveside, cradled in the weeds. Most of his community sensed he needed time to process his complex emotions... Leonor on the other hand found his way back and lay amongst the daisies.

“Jade’s been asking questions.” A stone dropped in Devin’s stomach.

“...About?”

“My scar.” The scar in question streaked across Leonor’s cheek like a bolting horse, wiry and straight. Devin swallowed the fear, guilt, rage, and pride that wracked his heart, like he always did.

“What did you tell them?”

“Nothing... yet. They’ve been here a while—maybe we should tell them the story.” Devin’s heart clenched.

“They’ve barely been here a year, we should wait *at least a couple* before we trust them so completely.” Devin was terrified of another ‘Alice’ situation. He stared back into Leonor’s relentless gaze, hoping that he would see what couldn’t be said, *again*.

“You’re right. Sometimes you have to take a few bites of the apple before you know if it’s decent or not. Bad idea to rush trust.” Devin wondered if his relief was palpable. The worry that Jade would start to notice the quiet tension, the fear, the defensiveness of

their little community kept him up at night. He wondered if they would notice the small faults in the far wall of the cellar kitchen, or stains of blood they hadn't caught. He obsessed over his part in the pain, and was overwhelmed with love for a community that came together to protect each other... Until Alice's 'crisis of conscience'.

"Thank you," whispered Leonor. "*Again.*" He rubbed at a tear caught in the grooves of his scar.

"We stand together or we don't stand at all." Devin's words were muffled. Bitter, perhaps. He dug his hands into the loose soil of the grave and spoke to where Alice's head now lay. "Still, after everything, I'd rather be on the hook than you in the grave."

"*Don't* say that." Leonor's fierce intensity was like a slap to the face. "We *protect* each other. She didn't do that, and I *need* you." Heartbeats passed with the two of them locked together in the dying light of the sun, a deep dread landing with the impact of a meteor. It *couldn't* be... He *couldn't* have...

We all watched her fall.

ONCE UPON A TIME

NOVA RIDDLE

Once upon a time, there were two women, a goddess, and an ocean.
The End.

Once upon a time, two women got married. The love of this marriage faded away, replaced by bickering and habit. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women fell in love. The goddess set them a task to build a house near the ocean. In the process, the women fell out of love. They stayed friends. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women went on vacation to a beachside hotel. They drowned in the ocean. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women bumped into each other at the beach. They never thought of each other again. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women stood on a beach readied for battle. They each prayed to the goddess for luck. They raised their weapons against each other. They battled for thirty days and thirty nights. Neither of them could best the other. They both died from exhaustion simultaneously. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women stood in a beach side café. They each ordered a pastry and a coffee. They didn't notice each other. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, a woman named Goddess met a girl named Ocean. Goddess watched. Ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two researchers met in a library in a coastal town. They both did research on an ancient goddess who used to be worshipped at the nearby beach. They excitedly discussed their thoughts. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women splashed water on each other at the beach. That day was their first kiss. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two priestesses worshipped a goddess near the ocean. Their mutual devotion brought them closer together. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. The End.

Once upon a time, two women fell in love. The goddess set them a task to build a house near the ocean. In the process, the women fell even more deeply in love. The goddess watched. The ocean stayed. the End.

Once upon a time, there were two women, a goddess, and an ocean. The End.

RENDING OF CREATION

ELOISE BLUMENTHAL

Decades had passed before she stepped over the threshold again.

A brilliant luminescence; tearing the gentle black sky's dotted lights from the Earth, the Rending of Creation. The sight of a God beyond comprehension by even herself, transient.

Carving its sovereignty into all that surrounded her. Smoke filled the still air before it, as the sirens continued to scream in agony, burning—it was all burning.

The ground fell to its knees in submission first, that much was trivial. And then, the shout of her divine authority demanding its sacrifice shattered through the air.

Rock and wood and metal and glass and dirt were all undone into the same turbulent smoke and ash, the burning animals, all churned together indiscriminately then emerged in her veil as it choked the air dry.

Shrouded in grey, the light vanished as quickly as it arrived, and gave birth to a new form, reaching beyond the limits of the sky itself.

It all happened so fast. Where was she now? Was that her, or did she fall as the light did? No one knew before it carried them away for her up-draft, that this moment would see them become one together to meet her shape.

Sundered from themselves, they give form to their wrathful God's lasting visage.

~

Their souls dissipated through the clouds, slowly, and the pain they felt for this birth would soon fall down upon their neighbours. Condemned for centuries of burning death.

They don't understand, they can't. She does, but it doesn't matter now; she can only cry with their blood.

Her memory gone, all that remains are the somnambulant cries of those left helpless when the heavens recede. Dazed by a light they find no trace of in this new world outside of themselves. Each tiny piece of it drifting into those left behind.

Unseen to them, all they feel is the heat it carries; continuing her path of conquest long after it cascaded beyond her, and she knew the fate to come.

This new world, in which there is but dead memory of her brilliance, and where to her all fear is pledged. This new world, of which her naked beauty made, in which she can never stand to face the depletion of her of power to atone. Now, it has no God before her. And it never will again.

The threshold is always approaching.

SINNERS

VANESSA ATALANTA

“Probably that fish curry I made when I was eighteen.”

Chloe laughed and elbowed Alice playfully in the ribs.

“I’m serious! The worst thing you’ve ever done. I bet you’ve got some really juicy skeletons in your closet.”

“Juicy skeletons?”

“Shut up.”

Alice glanced over her shoulder, as though there might be somebody else on the same rooftop listening in.

“You first,” she said at last.

“Yeah, okay. Uh, you know Shannon?”

“Yeah?”

Chloe looked out across the darkened cityscape. The trails of headlights weaved in and out of the patchwork lit-up windows.

“I’m not exactly proud of this but, uh... I slept with her a few times, back when she was still married to Jon.”

“Seriously?” Alice laughed. “I mean, that’s not that bad.”

“I bet Jon would disagree!”

“Sure, but it’s Shannon who did the actual betrayal here, not you. I don’t think that really counts.”

“Oh yeah? What’ve you done that’s so much worse, then?”

Alice looked away and idly swirled the mostly empty wine bottle in her left hand.

“Promise you won’t tell anyone?”

“Promise.”

“So, when I was younger I got really into cryptography and computer security. I fancied myself a real hacker, you know?”

“Right.”

“I managed to find an unsecured... well, the details don’t really matter, but I got into someone’s bank account. Nineteen thousand pounds. I converted it all to crypto and took it.”

Two heartbeats of silence passed.

“Nineteen thousand?” Chloe gave a short high pitched laugh.

“No wonder you could afford to always be so generous with money! I figured you just had rich parents. Hell, you’ve probably spent that money better than whoever had it originally.”

“It’s not funny! I took everything from someone. I probably ruined his life.”

Chloe snorted dismissively.

“Who the hell has nineteen thousand pounds just lying around anyway? I bet it wasn’t more than a setback for someone like that.”

A cold wave of nausea sank through Alice.

“What if it was all he had left from his wife’s life insurance payout? What if he was funding a small charity? What if—no, you don’t get it. The worst thing you’ve ever done is consensually sleep with someone, you can’t know what it’s like to do something truly bad. It eats you alive.”

The wind blew. Alice tugged her cardigan a little tighter around her shoulders. Somewhere far away, a siren cried out.

“Sorry, I—”

“I do. I do know what it’s like,” Chloe asserted, suddenly terribly sober. “I lied earlier. That’s not the worst thing I’ve done.” She faltered for a second, then continued, “I was fifteen. Full of rage at the world. Not that that’s an excuse. There was an abandoned railway bridge near my house, overlooking a road, and this guy came walking down there. He looked all smart and confident, carrying a briefcase and everything, and something about him just made me so angry I couldn’t take it.

“I took a big chunk of rubble—so big I could only just lift it—and pushed it over the edge of the bridge right as he passed underneath. I regretted it before it had even landed. And then, crack. Just this dull crack, like a melon splitting open. I ran home as fast as I could and threw up. I couldn’t eat anything for a week, and I kept taking hot showers to try to wash it off me. I didn’t look at the news for years. I still don’t dare read any news about my hometown just in case.”

“Jesus, Chloe, I’m sorry.”

She gazed across the skyline towards the spire of the cathedral.

“At least you can atone for what you did. You could find whoever it was and pay them back, or at least donate that much money to charity or something. I’m pretty sure I ended someone’s entire existence. There’s no coming back from that. And do you know what the most damning thing is? I found a way to live with it. I moved on, worked a job, hung out with my friends, just like any normal human being. Sometimes days go by when I don’t think about it at all. Anybody could kill someone, it takes a real monster to kill someone and continue living.”

Silence settled. The unspoken words piled up like snowflakes. Alice raised her arm to place it around Chloe’s shoulder, hesitated, and let it drop again. Chloe stared over the edge of the rooftop, down twelve stories to the void-black ground below.

“It’s a long way down from here, huh.”

“It’s a long way down,” Alice agreed quietly.

Y-SHAPED CITY

ELSPETH RUSHBROOK

You used to be simple, transcribed as a single letter of the alphabet. Your stalk ran and ran, curving a little after the fat part, transversing the river, making you look like a striking scorpion. You weren't the place that I would have originally chosen, if you wouldn't mind my saying. I would pass you, high up, looking down in all ways. You were a marker on a journey: three quarters of the way there, a quarter of the way back. You were not a destination of yourself. I didn't mind that for the first years, we – the train formed of twelve coaches, as announcements pointlessly inform – we would pass by, arching on arches, no need to stop. For who would alight here, who would make this place a destination?

Except when I did. It was for business – it always has been. To see a dear friend, see the house where she was chided by her banking father for inscribing her secret number on the bottom of an ornament. And then, for her special day, her coupling, one where I felt another number – an odd one. Then I wished that the trains did stop, rather than the faff of changing to get where I was already going.

Yes, you have always been visited for business, and not for real pleasure. The day I spent 8 hours in you alone was a challenge dictated by cheap advance tickets, not personal joy. I was glad of your river walk, the scrawny bits of green by the arching arches, and that it was a warm, dry day. I came only as you were the nearest place to see something, someone I wanted to.

That statement is true again now: you alone offer something in this region, something obtainable and appealing.

The reason of my coming to you is the reason that people always have: you're in a line between places we want to go, places of importance. You became one yourself – kind of. Your status has always surprised me, but I hear that it's not new. Why you?

You are not far from the mouth of the wolf looking out to sea, but you are not a crinkle even at the corners of that mouth. You are not its eye, its nose, its ear. You're a blush on its cheek, dictated by cartography as much as symmetry.

In your Y shaped days, you received people travelling 'cross the wolf's head, aiming diagonally for its neck, or the spectacles perched on its nose. That on a cloth bearing the wolf's image, you stand out is because the maker of the cloth chose that you did. You chose and

willed that you would, against the claims of rivals. I hear it was not a pretty competition. How did you come out on top?

Y comes late in the alphabet. I assumed you did too, sprouting when those arches did, or just before I sprouted, as a dwelling for commuters who did not want to live in a city. But now they do, and you can't decide if you want to be a country town, safer and less stressy, gentler and simpler, or if you wish to pretend you are a detached piece of a greater beast, or the beast in miniature.

The first time we met in years, I had a sneaking feeling. That although you're not my type (or types, there has been some variety) that I may fall in love. You did offer me kindness, and let me tell my story of love here, before we had any connection. But do we now?

It's been a while since I started to make a habit of you, descending from the arches, noting your spindly spire and industrial heritage, glad that you're mostly flat and that my business here is near. You are at least convenient, unlike the One I would normally prefer. I didn't think that I'd miss you, but just now, you felt pleasingly familiar, even though I said that you oppressed me on our second date.

I watched as winter set upon you, as graveyards turned rusty, as coat belts needed tying. Now it's almost time for the winter to be put away. Where bronzed droppings fell from on high, soon pink purses shall appear. Where I once threw confetti made by men on a feted pair, you will make your own, and throw it on us all. Whence before I saw you incrementally darken, I now witness that you are lit longer by the sun, rather than your floodlights. You look good either way. I like how you – for this part of you personifies you – are lit from within, as if your warm heart, like ET's, glows out of your body and into the world. I'm sure, as a minster, this is what you are meant to do.

You broadcast two things a century ago: that you are now a mother, and that you have always had an important father. You carved him in wellies in stone. You're as proud of your Celtic roots as locals are of being the place in the world that sent out first. A stranger told me that at a bus stop.

Although I was sated within an hour of taking your photo, for a project, not because you are ostensibly album-worthy, I am learning the why of your Y shape, and the warmth is felt on my skin. I am learning about the stems of the Y, the once crudely named fronds growing out of your side that lead to many green pastures, and quieter waters than I might have guessed. But do you restore my soul, which much needs restoration? I think you might. I've enjoyed dating, and hope you will receive me again, whether we move in or there's an offer to sit under your colourful canopy and receive.

Friends of Penelope is a Norfolk-based writing club with members from across the UK and beyond. We are a collective of queer writers who are inspired by the worlds both inside and around us to capture unique moments of our lives, which *Friends of Penelope Volume Two* explores. The arts are often a reflection of real life and that leads many of us not only to the darker themes seen in some of the stories in this anthology, but also to the precious moments of hope seen in others.

We'd like to thank you for taking the time to read our second publication and supporting our contestants. We hope you enjoy our work.

Thank you to Lisa Mac for judging our competition, and congratulations to Ruadhán Ó Donnaile who won first place! May there be many more winners to come.